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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



‘YOU DON’T BOW DOWN TO THE HATER’

As the Rev. Michael Pfleger marks 50 years in the priesthood — including more than 40 at the predominantly Black St. Sabina Church in Chicago’s Auburn Gresham neighborhood — parishioners stand by his dedication to social justice and his unwillingness to fold in the face of controversy

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

The Rev. Michael Pfleger’s initial idea for celebrating 50 years in the priesthood was simple: do nothing. But for Chicago Cardinal Blase Cupich, that was unacceptable. “He called me up, and he said, ‘What are you doing for your 50th?’ and I said, ‘I’m not doing anything,’” Pfleger recalled as Cupich stood next to him at an anniversary celebration on Chicago’s South Side this week. “And he says, ‘You gotta do something for your 50th.’ And he’s my boss, and I always do what he says.”

The comment got a laugh from the crowd, many of them longtime parishioners at St. Sabina Church and familiar with the pastor’s penchant for bucking authority.

The outspoken priest, at the cardinal’s urging, eventually came up with an idea.

“I wanted to bless the community,” Pfleger said.

And with that, the 75-year-old Pfleger decided to host an all-day event to honor the 50th anniversary of his ordination. The church hosted a gun turn-in and gun lock giveaway throughout much of Wednesday. At noon, the church gave away 400 boxes of free food, followed by an afternoon carnival for kids in the



Above: The Rev. Michael Pfleger reads in the St. Sabina Church study in 1981, the year he became pastor of the South Side parish. **ARTHUR WALKER/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Top: Cardinal Blase Cupich, center left, walks with Pfleger outside St. Sabina Church on Wednesday. The cardinal recently returned from the conclave that elected Pope Leo XIV. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

church parking lot that featured two bouncy castles, a petting zoo and grilled hot dogs and hamburgers.

The Chicago-born priest has been a fixture at the predominantly Black St. Sabina Church — and in the Auburn Gresham community — since being assigned to the parish more than 40 years ago. Parishioners described the pastor as someone who truly practices what he preaches and expressed gratitude for his relentless dedication to social justice, which at times has put him in the national spotlight and at the center of controversy.

His dedication to activism has meant holding protests — including one that resulted in an arrest in 2007 — outside of a suburban gun shop, which later closed its doors. He led a shut down of the Dan Ryan Expressway in 2018, calling for stricter gun legislation. He has successfully called for the removal of tobacco and liquor billboards in the Auburn Gresham neighborhood and other parts of the city. He even took on “The Jerry Springer Show,” accusing it of glorifying violence for its viewers.

In 1966, when he was a teenager, Pfleger he ventured to Marquette Park to watch a civil rights protest that the Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King

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Bears refocus plan on suburb

Arlington Heights stadium would need ‘megaproject’ legislation from Springfield

By Robert McCoppin,
Jeremy Gornier, Dan Petrella
and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Bears are shifting their focus for a new stadium away from the city’s lakefront and back to Arlington Heights and a project that would depend on legislative action in Springfield allowing for negotiated financing of large-scale developments.

“Over the last few months, we have made significant progress with the leaders in Arlington Heights, and look forward to continuing to work with state and local leaders on making a transformative economic development project for the region a reality,” the team said in a statement to the Tribune on Friday.

The Bears said they will not seek state funding for a stadium in the northwest suburb. That would be welcome news in Springfield, where Gov. JB Pritzker and key lawmakers have repeatedly shown no enthusiasm for putting taxpayer money toward a stadium.

The team is likely, however, to seek state funding for infrastructure.

The Bears would likely need “megaproject” legislation that would allow them to negotiate with local governments over property tax bills. With only two weeks to go in the spring legislative session, passing such a measure quickly might be a tall order, especially for Chicago lawmakers with an interest in keeping the team in the city.

“I don’t know who works with the Bears on their timing, but I would say ... they’ve mastered the art of bad timing,” said state Sen. Robert Peters, a progressive Democrat from Chicago who has announced a congressional run and

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INSIDE Conservatives scuttle House spending bill

House Republicans failed Friday to push their big package of tax breaks and spending cuts through the Budget Committee as a handful of conservative lawmakers joined all Democrats in a stunning vote against it. The hard-right lawmakers are insisting on steeper spending cuts to Medicaid and the Biden-era green energy tax breaks, among other changes. **Nation & World**



CITY SERIES: Friday’s series opener at Wrigley Field took a back seat to summer vibes, at least for the White Sox fans in attendance, as the Cubs scored a 13-3 win over their rivals. **Chicago Sports**

Election tests CTU strategy, solidarity



By Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

A group of dissenting educators was challenging Chicago Teachers Union President Stacy Davis Gates and her squad in a union election Friday.

The opposition slate argues that the current leadership’s bullish nature doesn’t allow for dissenting voices, lacks financial transparency and has shed union allies. Davis Gates’ opponent for president, Erika Meza, a 25-year veteran teacher from the Southeast Side, is unhappy with what CTU has come to symbolize.

“There’s a lack of solidarity right now. We want to bring that back,” Meza said in an interview with the Tribune. “We need to

make this a decision for the whole union.”

This election is about more than the two parties within the union. It’s about CTU’s priorities and values at a time when polling shows its popularity across the city has declined. And questions about representation and race have emerged as a subtext.

The election also comes as Chicago Public Schools has an estimated \$529 million deficit for its 2026 fiscal year while facing increased attacks on public education from the federal government, presenting challenges for the district’s next leader.

Davis Gates has a long history with labor and organizing. She has been CTU president since 2022 and was vice president

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Alison Eichhorn, left, vice presidential candidate, and Erika Meza, presidential candidate, are challenging CTU leadership. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

